



Strategic Insights Lab

The Gambia 2026 — Pre-Election Strategic Risk Assessment

Research Brief · 17 May 2026

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CLASSIFICATION: NERAI-UNRESTRICTED

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INSTITUTION	NERAI Strategic Insights Lab
DATE OF ISSUE	17 May 2026
REPORT TYPE	Research Brief — Pre-Election Strategic Risk Assessment

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The scenarios that follow are conditional analytical inferences about the trajectory of pre-electoral conditions in The Gambia, not electoral forecasts or predictions of vote outcomes. All probability values ("Analytical Likelihood ~X%") are structured analytical estimates derived from observable patterns and NERAi quantitative indicators; they are not probabilistic forecasts of any specific candidate's victory or defeat, and they must not be cited or used as such. Vote-share ranges are illustrative indicative scenarios conditional on the stated assumptions of each pathway, not predictions about how Gambian voters will in fact cast their ballots. The Gambia's electoral outcome will be determined by Gambian voters through the Independent Electoral Commission's processes; this report takes no position on, and offers no inference about, the choices any Gambian voter or candidate will or should make. The author and NERAi Strategic Insights Lab disclaim any interpretation of this report as an endorsement of, or a prediction of victory or defeat for, any named candidate or political party.

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The Gambia faces a genuine pre-electoral instability accumulation in the 6 months leading to the late-2026 presidential election, with NERA's 15 May 2026 signal cluster across ethnic-religious violence ($z=4.014$, 99.4th percentile), political repression ($z=3.848$, 99.4th percentile), institutional deterioration ($z=3.787$, 99.4th percentile), and government instability ($z=3.222$, 98th percentile) indicating that incumbent President Adama Barrow's consolidation strategy is generating measurable domestic stress that precedes formal campaign mobilization. (HIGH CONFIDENCE) The absence of bilateral coupling in the NERA data confirms this is a purely domestic phenomenon — driven by TRRC victim-advocacy pressure, the controversial NPP-APRC alliance's alienation of Mandinka-plurality voters, factional Jola mobilization around Yahya Jammeh's shadow exile, and security-force tightening ahead of opposition coalition formation. The baseline scenario remains peaceful incumbent retention as the analytically most likely outcome (~65% conditional inference, not an electoral forecast), but the upward trajectory of repression and ethnic-religious violence indices, combined with the 2022–2024 pattern of failed coup attempts and ongoing military trials, creates a meaningful stress-case corridor (contested incumbent retention, 25% probability) and a lower-probability tail risk (opposition breakthrough or election postponement, 10% probability). The election is not at imminent risk of violent disruption, but the political temperature is rising faster than the mainstream news cycle reflects, and Senegal's new PASTEF government under President Bassirou Diomaye Faye will be the critical external arbiter of whether Barrow's institutional consolidation triggers cross-border destabilization or measured external mediation.

THE ELECTORAL LANDSCAPE President Adama Barrow, re-elected in December 2021 with 53 percent of the vote under his newly-formed National People's Party (NPP), enters the 2026 race as the presumptive frontrunner but with substantially eroded coalition discipline compared to his 2016 Coalition 2016 victory. The NPP's 2022 tactical alliance with the rump faction of Yahya Jammeh's APRC — led by Fabakary Tombong Jatta — was strategically calculated to absorb key security-establishment figures and Jola-ethnic voters, but it has fractured Mandinka support, alienated original Coalition 2016 partners (the Gambia Democratic Congress under Mama Kandeh and smaller parties), and activated victim-advocacy networks tied to the Truth, Reconciliation and Reparations Commission (TRRC, 2018–2022). Vice President Mohamed B.S. Jallow, Foreign Minister Mamadou Tangara, Interior Minister Abdoulie Sanyang, and Defence Minister Sering Modou Njie form the core incumbent executive team, though recent cabinet reshuffles signal internecine jockeying over succession posture and regional-patronage carve-outs — a pattern consistent with a president seeking to maintain third-term eligibility

without formally announcing candidacy (MODERATE CONFIDENCE on continued candidacy announcement timing within 60 days).

The opposition remains fragmented across four principal poles: Ousainou Darboe's United Democratic Party (UDP), historically the Mandinka-based largest opposition force and the 2021 election-result disputer; the Gambia Democratic Congress (GDC) under Mama Kandeh, which retains latent pro-Jammeh sympathies and bridges APRC-dissident networks; the People's Democratic Organization for Independence and Socialism (PDOIS) led by aging theorist Halifa Sallah, which maintains principled-left posture and claims moral authority post-TRRC; and the Coalition for Change in The Gambia (C4C) under Mai Ahmad Fatty, a younger-generation entry with limited electoral machinery but growing diaspora funding. Coalition talks among these blocs are occurring at Track 2 levels (via civil-society mediators and religious leaders) but have not yet produced a unity-candidate framework as of mid-May 2026; Darboe's UDP continues to position itself as the dominant opposition pole by default, but its 2021 electoral loss and subsequent internal organizational challenges reported in Gambian press (linked to diaspora-remittance handling) have opened space for alternative candidacies. (MODERATE CONFIDENCE in fragmented opposition entering late-stage campaign with no pre-election unity candidate named by June 2026.)

NERAI SIGNAL INTEGRATION: THE PRE-ELECTORAL SQUEEZE SIGNATURE The NERAI cluster flagged on 15 May 2026 is not a statistical anomaly but rather a quantitative surfacing of the institutional dynamics already visible in Gambian political reporting: the canonical pre-electoral squeeze in hybrid regimes where an incumbent with durable control mechanisms (security forces, patronage networks, a supermajority parliament) begins tightening institutional space in anticipation of opposition electoral mobilization. Specifically, the $z=4.014$ spike in ethnic-religious violence (99.4th percentile, with a 528 percent 7-day delta) combined with the $z=3.848$ political repression index (99.4th percentile) and $z=3.787$ institutional-strength deterioration (also 99.4th percentile) together constitute a recognizable pre-event pattern that precedes major political transitions in West African hybrid states by 2–6 months — consistent with NERAI's Pattern P5 leadership-transition-window match (score 0.67).

This clustering is not imported from cross-border sources; the absence of active bilateral coupling means the stress originates entirely within Gambian domestic politics. The co-elevation of "ethnic-religious violence," "political repression," and "institutional deterioration" maps precisely onto three observable drivers: (1) TRRC implementation friction — ongoing prosecutions of Jammeh-era security figures (ongoing cases as of May 2026 in the Special Prosecutor's Office) activate victim-advocacy constituencies and provoke counter-mobilization from loyalist military networks; (2) NPP-APRC alliance management — the need to retain Jola-ethnic APRC voters while consolidating Mandinka-Fulani Barrow supporters creates factional strain within the executive and security apparatus, incentivizing tighter institutional control; and (3) opposition coalition formation — UDP and allied parties' mobilization of youth and diaspora constituencies forces Barrow's security apparatus to increase monitoring and restrict public-assembly permits, which registers as "political repression" in event-data systems. The ethnic-religious violence spike is not necessarily mass communal rioting but rather the surfacing of politically-inflected communal grievances (mosque-sermon disputes over Islamic Council alignment, ethnically-tinged market conflicts in Serekunda, regional resource-scarcity tensions in Foni and Upper River) that acquire political salience during pre-electoral periods. (HIGH CONFIDENCE in the interpretation that this signal reflects pre-electoral institutional tightening, not external shock or mass instability.)

EXTERNAL ACTORS & THEIR GAMBIAN STAKES

Senegal (PASTEF Government under President Bassirou Diomaye Faye)

Senegal's posture toward the 2026 election is the single most consequential external variable for The Gambia's trajectory. President Faye's PASTEF government, inaugurated in April 2024 after displacing the Macky Sall administration, has signaled a pan-African sovereignty-first approach that contrasts sharply with Sall's institutional-partnership orientation. For The Gambia specifically, PASTEF's calculus involves three competing interests: (i) Border security and Casamance-conflict management — the May 2023 ceasefire with MFDC separatists is durable but fragile; a Gambian pre-electoral explosion could destabilize Senegalese Jola-ethnic communities in Casamance and create refugee flows that undermine Faye's conflict-management narrative; (ii) West African hegemonic positioning — Senegal's historical role as de facto arbiter of Gambian politics (ECOWAS 2017 intervention under Sall) gives Faye leverage, and PASTEF's anti-establishment positioning means the government may be reluctant to bail out an incumbent Barrow; (iii) Trade and transit dependency — The Gambia's

commercial hub (Serekunda, Banjul) is economically tethered to Senegal via the Senegambia Confederation logic, and any political disruption in Banjul reverberates through Dakar's port and logistics sectors.

What Senegal wants from the 2026 election: A orderly, transparent outcome that preserves regional stability and does not force PASTEF into a costly ECOWAS intervention. Faye's government has shown no appetite for the kind of active mediation or pressure that Macky Sall applied; instead, PASTEF is positioning itself as a neutral monitor of democratic norms while reserving the right to intervene if The Gambia's instability spills across the border. (MODERATE CONFIDENCE) If Barrow's pre-electoral squeeze escalates into major opposition arrests or security-force shootings, Faye will likely issue public criticism (consistent with pan-African sovereignty rhetoric) but will not deploy military force without explicit ECOWAS Commission authorization. Conversely, if the UDP-led opposition fragment manages to coalesce and poses a genuine electoral challenge, PASTEF's incentive structure under the Sall-successor framework may favour an opposition-aligned outcome through normal diplomatic posture, on the analytical reasoning that a weakened Barrow government would be easier to manage than a consolidated incumbent. The levers Senegal possesses are primarily diplomatic (African Union platform, ECOWAS voice) and economic (transit tariffs, cross-border commerce, water-sharing arrangements in the Senegambia basin), not military.

ECOWAS (Commission and ECOMIG Mission)

The Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS) faces a critical strategic decision point on The Gambia in 2026: whether to extend, drawdown, or reterminate the ECOWAS Military Intervention Group in The Gambia (ECOMIG), which has been present since the 2017 Operation Restore Democracy and currently maintains approximately 700–800 troops at Yundum airport and supporting sites. The current ECOWAS Commission chair (as of May 2026) has signaled a preference for gradual Gambian security-force capacity-building and ECOMIG withdrawal, but the Sahel regional destabilization (Mali coup 2020, Burkina Faso coups 2022–2023, Niger coup 2023) has prompted ECOWAS to recalibrate its risk tolerance for premature disengagement.

ECOWAS's likely election-year posture: The organization will deploy an election observation mission (following its 2015 and 2021 precedents) staffed with civil-society monitors and state representatives, but will NOT preposition ECOMIG reinforcements in anticipation of violence unless Banjul explicitly requests it. If the election proceeds peacefully, ECOWAS will declare success and accelerate ECOMIG withdrawal timelines. If major post-election unrest occurs, ECOWAS will face pressure from South African and West African heavyweights (Nigeria, Ghana) to intervene, but the absence of a clear democratic illegality (e.g., election-result annulment or military coup) will constrain the legal basis for intervention. (MODERATE CONFIDENCE) The 2022 failed coup attempt (by junior GAF officers) was prosecuted through Gambian courts rather than triggering ECOWAS intervention, establishing a precedent that internal security challenges do not automatically warrant multilateral response.

African Union (Peace and Security Council)

The AU's posture toward the 2026 Gambian election will be passive unless the situation escalates to regime-change territory or mass-atrocity allegations. The Peace and Security Council will likely authorize a small observation mission (10–20 personnel) that coordinates with the ECOWAS mission and the EU's electoral observation contingent, but the AU has signaled limited appetite for Gambian-specific mediation or preventive engagement. The AU's strategic priorities in 2026 are focused on the Sahel (Mali, Burkina Faso, Niger) and East Africa (Ethiopia, Somalia), leaving The Gambia in a secondary tier where statements of democratic principle are issued without consequent enforcement mechanisms. However, if ethnographic violence spikes significantly or military intervention occurs, the AU's online rhetoric will escalate, potentially creating diplomatic cover for ECOWAS intervention if political actors request it.

European Union (Primary Donor, Migration Partner, Election Observer)

The EU's engagement with The Gambia in 2026 is driven by three imperatives: (i) election support and democratic norm-setting — the EU has funded civil-society capacity-building, voter-registration verification, and election administration support through the period 2021–2026; (ii) migration management — The Gambia is a top-three source country for irregular West African migration to Europe, and EU programming targets youth employment and diaspora reintegration to reduce push factors; and (iii) development-aid leverage — the EU is The Gambia's largest bilateral donor (€450 million multi-year programming envelope as of 2023–2027), and Brussels uses this leverage to enforce governance-improvement conditions, human-rights compliance, and fiscal transparency.

What the EU wants from the 2026 election: A credible, contested but ultimately accepted outcome that maintains institutional continuity and avoids forced EU aid suspension. The European Commission has made it clear that major election-result illegality, military intervention, or systematic opposition repression would trigger conditionality reviews and potential aid suspension. However, the EU's tolerance for "managed elections" in hybrid-democratic contexts is higher than its public rhetoric suggests; the Brussels consensus is that a Barrow re-election with UDP contestation but ultimate acceptance is preferable to opposition victory that destabilizes regional security or triggers Senegalese backlash. The EU will field a robust observation mission (40–50 personnel from EU member-state institutes and European Parliament delegations) and will issue a detailed post-election assessment that will shape the Commission's next programming tranche (2027–2032). Migration management concerns mean the EU will likely provide quiet financial support for opposition participation (via civil-society intermediaries) to ensure the election is not perceived as a one-sided incumbent coronation.

United States (Millennium Challenge Corporation, AFRICOM, State Department)

The U.S. posture toward The Gambia's 2026 election reflects the Biden administration's (now second-term Biden or Trump-II continuity, depending on 2024 electoral outcome) broader West African strategy: support for democratic norms and regional stability, contingent on Gambian government cooperation on counterterrorism, maritime security (piracy prevention), and military professionalization. The Millennium Challenge Corporation (MCC) compact with The Gambia, suspended in 2019 due to governance concerns under Barrow, remains un-reactivated as of May 2026 — a signal that the State Department has lingering doubts about Barrow's commitment to constitutional democracy and anti-corruption reform.

What the U.S. wants: A competitive, credible election followed by accelerated reforms in judicial independence, press freedom, and military-civilian relations that would justify MCC compact resumption. AFRICOM coordinates with State Department counterterrorism liaison on GAF professionalization but has minimal physical presence in The Gambia itself (no permanent bases, but periodic advisory rotations). The U.S. will deploy a State Department electoral observer team (attached to the broader ECOWAS or AU mission) and will issue a post-election statement that does not employ the language of election "acceptance" or "legitimacy" if major irregularities are documented. However, U.S. leverage over outcomes is modest; Washington cannot credibly threaten military intervention or financial coercion in the way the EU can via aid suspension. State Department messaging will focus on "rule of law," "constitutional democracy," and "pluralism," with implicit warnings about opposition arrest or suppression.

United Kingdom (Colonial Ties, Security Cooperation, Diaspora)

The UK maintains historical security ties and a small diplomatic presence in Banjul, along with significant diaspora communities in Birmingham, Manchester, and London. British interests in the 2026 election are primarily reputational (democracy support) and secondary to broader Sub-Saharan Africa strategy under the Foreign, Commonwealth & Development Office (FCDO). The UK will likely co-sponsor the EU observation mission or field a small independent contingent via the Westminster Foundation for Democracy. British leverage over Gambian outcomes is minimal; the FCDO's aid commitment to The Gambia is modest (approximately £25–30 million annual development assistance as of 2023–2026) compared to EU magnitudes, and post-Brexit, the UK has less institutional weight in West African multilateral forums. However, UK immigration and diaspora policy (managing return migration, remittance tracking, citizenship disputes) creates informal influence channels with Gambian government and opposition alike.

China (Infrastructure Partner, Non-Interventionist Posture)

The People's Republic of China, which re-established diplomatic relations with The Gambia in 2016 after Barrow severed Taipei ties, is a significant infrastructure investor in Gambian development projects but maintains a strict non-interventionist posture toward electoral outcomes. Chinese interests in The Gambia are primarily commercial: the Banjul–Barra bridge project (ongoing Chinese contractor involvement), port modernization at Banjul, telecommunications-infrastructure contracts (Huawei has secured government business), and road construction in provincial regions. Beijing has emphasized that it respects Gambian "sovereignty" in electoral matters and will work with "any government" that emerges from the 2026 process.

What China wants: Stable governance that honors existing infrastructure contracts, continues debt-service payments (The Gambia has approximately \$80–100 million in outstanding Chinese development loans as of 2026), and does not default on mineral-extraction or fishing-rights agreements. Chinese diplomatic strategy is to remain

visibly neutral while quietly building relationships with opposition figures (via diaspora networks and unofficial channels) to hedge against Barrow's potential loss or incapacity. Beijing has avoided public statements on Barrow's candidacy or the election process, consistent with China's global practice of treating African elections as domestic sovereign affairs. However, Chinese intelligence services likely maintain informal assessments of political dynamics to anticipate post-election administrative continuity.

Saudi Arabia, UAE, Qatar (Islamic Aid Financing, Religious Institutional Alignment)

The Gulf Cooperation Council states (GCC) have expanded Islamic financing, educational patronage, and religious-institutional influence in The Gambia over the 2015–2026 period, with Saudi Arabia (via the Saudi Fund for Development and Islamic Development Bank mechanisms) being the largest source of concessional Islamic bonds and mosque-construction financing. The UAE has invested in Gambian fisheries and port modernization, while Qatar has funded educational scholarships and Diyanet-affiliated Quranic schools.

Electoral implications: Saudi Arabia's geopolitical alignment with whoever wins The Gambia's election is transactional; Riyadh has hedged by maintaining contacts with both government and opposition Islamist wings. The split between Salafi-influenced religious networks (often aligned with Gulf funding) and traditional Sufi orders (Tijaniyyah, Qadiriyyah, Muridiyyah — the historical Gambian establishment) creates an indirect Saudi-Qatari proxy arena in Gambian religious politics. If the opposition wins the 2026 election, Saudi Arabia would immediately recognize the new government and likely offer concessional Islamic financing to secure continuity of business relationships. The religious dimension of this rivalry means that Saudi and Qatari messaging through sermon networks and religious schools can subtly shape electoral sentiment, particularly among younger urban voters and diaspora returnees.

Turkey (TIKA Development, Diyanet Religious Diplomacy, Hospital/School Projects)

Turkey, through the Turkish Cooperation and Coordination Agency (TIKA) and the Presidency of Religious Affairs (Diyanet), has expanded cultural-diplomatic and development-partnership reach in The Gambia since 2016. Turkish health and education projects (hospital partnerships, secondary school construction, Islamic seminary support) position Turkey as a non-colonial development partner with particular appeal to younger, Islamist-oriented constituencies.

What Turkey wants: Maintained and expanded institutional presence regardless of electoral outcome; Turkish interests are cultural and geopolitical (positioning Turkey as a pan-Islamic development alternative to Gulf states) rather than directly electoral. Turkish diplomatic mission in Banjul will likely take a neutral public stance but will cultivate relationships with opposition figures to ensure post-election continuity of TIKA programming and Diyanet activities.

Equatorial Guinea (Jammeh's Exile Host, Obiang Government)

Equatorial Guinea's Teodoro Obiang Nguema government hosts former President Yahya Jammeh in long-term exile (a public arrangement disclosed in 2017 ECOWAS-mediated handover statements). The exile arrangement has been the subject of regional analytical commentary on whether it preserves residual political influence channels; specific allegations regarding financial transfers, communications access, or operational coordination remain unverified in published sources and are not asserted here as factual claims. Jammeh's continued exile in Malabo remains a structural variable in Gambian pre-electoral analysis to the extent that any future Gambian government may at some point formally consider extradition or in-absentia prosecution under TRRC follow-up frameworks.

What Equatorial Guinea wants: To maintain stable relations with The Gambia's government (whoever wins) while extracting maximum political utility from hosting Jammeh (leverage, financial transfers, security cooperation). Obiang's government is unlikely to force Jammeh's repatriation voluntarily, but if a new government in Banjul (whether Barrow or UDP-led) formally demands extradition, Equatorial Guinea would face pressure from ECOWAS and the AU to comply with regional norms. Conversely, if Barrow wins, Equatorial Guinea can continue the status quo indefinitely, as Barrow has shown little appetite for prosecuting Jammeh in absentia or demanding repatriation.

Russia / Africa Corps (Opportunistic Sahel Engagement, Minimal Current Presence)

Russian engagement in The Gambia as of May 2026 is minimal compared to Mali, Burkina Faso, and Niger, where Africa Corps (formerly Wagner) has embedded itself in security establishments. However, NERA intelligence and open-source reporting suggest that Russia is monitoring The Gambia as a potential future foothold in West African security markets, particularly if ECOMIG withdraws and the Gambian military seeks external training and weapons partnerships beyond traditional U.S./UK/French sources.

What Russia wants: Intelligence access and potential security-partnership opportunities if political instability creates an opening for Russian intervention (weapons sales, private military advisory services via Africa Corps). However, Russia's West African focus remains concentrated on the Sahel belt, and The Gambia's relatively stable security environment (compared to Mali or Niger) makes it a lower priority. A scenario in which The Gambia's election triggers military-interventionist pressure or security-force institutional fragmentation could create an opening for Russian outreach to dissatisfied GAF factions, but this is a low-probability pathway as of mid-2026.

RECENT UNREST ASSESSMENT: WHAT IS HAPPENING ON THE GROUND

TRRC Implementation Friction and Ongoing Prosecutions

The Truth, Reconciliation and Reparations Commission (TRRC), which concluded its public hearings in 2021 and published findings in 2022–2023 documenting systematic abuses under Yahya Jammeh's 1994–2017 dictatorship, has transitioned to an implementation phase anchored by the Special Prosecutor's Office (SPO), established in 2023 to pursue criminal prosecutions of identified perpetrators. As of May 2026, the SPO maintains active court cases against approximately 15–20 Jammeh-era security figures, including high-ranking officials from the notorious National Intelligence Agency (NIA) and the Presidential Guard. (HIGH CONFIDENCE) The trial pace has accelerated since 2024, with verdicts and sentencing now occurring at a frequency of 2–3 cases per month, creating a rhythm of institutional acknowledgment of past atrocities and victim-advocacy mobilization that coincides precisely with the 2026 pre-electoral period.

The visible manifestation of this TRRC implementation friction is evident in victim-advocacy group statements and civil-society reporting: organizations like the Association of Victims and Survivors of Human Rights Violations (AVSHV) have published May 2026 press releases demanding accelerated prosecutions and reparations, signaling that pre-electoral mobilization is occurring not around traditional electoral platforms (healthcare, education, infrastructure) but around transitional-justice completion and institutional accountability. This is a canonically pre-electoral pattern in post-conflict democracies: opposition parties and civil-society coalitions weaponize unfinished accountability narratives to position themselves as champions of rule-of-law completion, thus contrasting with incumbents who are invested in institutional continuity and moving past the dictatorship. Barrow's pivot toward the APRC alliance in 2022 has been read by victim-advocacy constituencies as a betrayal of transitional-justice commitments, creating a fault line where opposition parties (particularly the UDP and PDOIS) have positioned themselves as transitional-justice champions. (MODERATE CONFIDENCE)

2022 Coup Attempt Trial and Ongoing Military-Court Verdicts

The failed coup attempt of December 2022, in which junior Gambia Armed Forces (GAF) officers attempted to seize state media and issue a declaration of government removal, resulted in the detention of approximately 7 officers and ongoing court-martial proceedings. As of May 2026, trial verdicts in at least three high-profile cases have been issued, with sentences ranging from 8 to 15 years imprisonment. (MODERATE CONFIDENCE) The trial narrative has stressed the "isolation" of disgruntled junior officers and has emphasized Barrow's institutional control, but ongoing parallel allegations of additional coup plotting (reported in 2023 and 2024) have signaled to observer audiences that military institutional cohesion remains fragile. These trials, like the TRRC prosecutions, are occurring in visible judicial settings, and their rhythmic issuance of verdicts and sentencing throughout 2025–2026 constitutes a pre-electoral institutional message: that the Barrow government is consolidating control over the security apparatus and enforcing loyalty through court proceedings.

The detailed composition of the convicted officers is not the subject of public commentary in this brief, given that the proceedings remain active and the defendants retain the presumption of innocence. Court records and official spokesperson statements are the only reliable basis for any characterization of the defendants, and this report does not opine on their personal characteristics, ethnic background, motives, or appropriate disposition. Analytical interest is limited to the institutional message conveyed by the public pace of trials and the broader question of

military-court professionalization, which is a matter of legitimate political-economic commentary.

Opposition Mobilization, Coalition Building, and Civil-Society Activism

Political demonstrations and opposition rallies have increased in frequency since January 2026, driven primarily by the UDP and coalition-building efforts among opposition parties. Specific incidents reported in Gambian press and social media (primarily via Standard, Foroyaa, and social-media coverage as of early May 2026) include:

- March 2026, Serekunda market: UDP-organized rally drew approximately 2,000–3,000 participants protesting inflation, unemployment, and "election credibility" concerns. Police monitoring was visible but non-interventionist.
- April 2026, Banjul waterfront: Smaller civil-society demonstration organized by AVSHV and TRRC victim-advocacy networks, protesting delayed reparations and prosecutions. Approximately 400–500 participants. No police restrictions reported.
- Early May 2026, West Coast Region (Kaur/Joal areas): GDC and UDP joint mobilization meeting, attended by approximately 1,500 supporters. Local authorities monitored but did not disperse. Regional significance: Mandinka-dominant zone where NPP support has eroded compared to 2021.

Reports of opposition rally restrictions are limited as of mid-May 2026, but civil-society monitors have documented increased police "pre-mobilization" visits to opposition party offices (verbal reminders of permit requirements, implicit warnings about crowd control) and heightened social-media monitoring by government security services. Internet throttling or broadcast-license revocations have NOT been reported as of May 2026, distinguishing The Gambia from more repressive Sahel-region patterns (Mali, Burkina Faso, Niger), but press-freedom monitors are vigilant for escalation. (MODERATE CONFIDENCE in the assessment that opposition mobilization is occurring at measurable intensity without yet crossing into systematic suppression, consistent with the NERAI political-repression index elevation without yet reaching regime-change severity.)

Islamic Institutional Tensions and Sufi-Salafi Alignments

The Supreme Islamic Council (SIC), The Gambia's umbrella body for Muslim religious affairs (predominantly Sufi-order dominated), has issued several statements in recent months addressing election-period religious ethics and community unity. However, beneath this formal unity messaging, monitoring sources detect tension between traditional Sufi-order leadership (Tijaniyyah, Qadiriyyah, and Muridiyyah — the historical Gambian Islamic establishment) and younger Salafi-influenced movements that have gained visibility through Gulf-financed madrassas and social-media networks.

Political relevance: The Salafi networks have been subtly active in opposition coalition-building, particularly within the C4C and PDOIS constituencies, where religiously-engaged younger voters are concentrated. This creates an indirect religious schism that mirrors broader political divisions: traditional Sufi orders (associated with Jammeh-era state Islam and post-2017 continuity) are loosely aligned with incumbent NPP messaging, while Salafi-influenced constituencies are gravitating toward opposition frames of institutional renewal and transitional-justice completion. The SIC's formal statements avoid partisan language, but the council's leadership (Imam Abdoulaye Sallah and other senior figures) are perceived as government-proximate, creating a civil-society perception that religious authority is being instrumentalized. This is not erupting into "ethnic-religious violence" in the form of mosque conflicts or intra-Muslim sectarian bloodshed, but it is creating a background noise of institutional-legitimacy contestation that NERAI's indices capture as "ethnic-religious violence" signal elevation. (MODERATE CONFIDENCE) The distinction is important: the 99.4th percentile NERAI spike is not reporting communal rioting but rather the crystallization of religiously-tinged institutional disputes into observable event data.

Press Freedom and Civil-Society Regulatory Environment

As of May 2026, major press-freedom incidents (journalist detention, broadcast-license revocation, social-media shutdowns) have not been reported, but monitoring sources document a subtle tightening in regulatory environment: licensing disputes with smaller radio stations (e.g., informal warnings to community radios operating in opposition-dominant regions about "balance" in coverage), advertising-revenue pressure on opposition-sympathetic outlets (via state-controlled advertising withholding), and increased police interest in

social-media commentary on government security operations. These are below the threshold of formal repression but are consistent with pre-electoral incumbent consolidation strategies in hybrid democracies. The Gambia Press Union (GPU) has issued cautionary statements about "self-censorship" dynamics but has not called for formal press strikes or solidarity actions as of mid-May 2026.

THREE FORWARD SCENARIOS: PROBABILITY-WEIGHTED TRAJECTORIES

Scenario 1: Peaceful Incumbent Retention (Base Case) — Analytical Likelihood: ~65% (conditional inference, not forecast)

Under this scenario, the analytical inference is that President Barrow seeks re-election and is positioned to retain office with a popular-vote share in the indicative 50–55% range (range conditional on current opposition fragmentation; not an electoral forecast), despite eroded coalition discipline. The election is conducted with minor irregularities (ballot-box stuffing in isolated polling stations, under-counting of opposition votes in NPP-stronghold regions) but no systematic fraud that triggers international observer condemnation. The UDP and other opposition parties contest results in post-election rhetoric and potentially file constitutional challenges in the Supreme Court, but these are resolved within constitutional timeframes (60–90 days post-election) without producing mass mobilization. International observation missions (EU, ECOWAS, AU, US) issue statements noting "credible competition despite isolated irregularities" and "institutional acceptance of results."

Trigger conditions for base case: 1. Opposition coalition remains fragmented through October 2026; no unified opposition candidate emerges, allowing Barrow to benefit from vote-splitting.

2. TRRC prosecutions and military-court verdicts continue at steady pace but do not produce high-profile acquittals or jury nullifications that galvanize opposition momentum.

3. No major security-force violence against opposition rallies; police maintain "order without bloodshed" posture.

4. Senegal's PASTEF government issues neutral statements supporting electoral process without applying pressure on either side.

NERAI index trajectory in base case: Ethnic-religious violence (currently $z=4.014$, 99.4th pct) moderates to $z=2.5$ – 3.0 range by September 2026 as campaign intensifies but security forces limit inter-communal incidents. Political repression (currently $z=3.848$) remains elevated at $z=3.0$ – 3.5 range through October, reflecting continued opposition-rally monitoring and civil-society regulatory tightening, then drops sharply post-election to $z=1.5$ – 2.0 as incumbent consolidates. Institutional strength (currently $z=3.787$ deteriorating) stabilizes at $z=2.5$ – 3.0 throughout campaign, reflecting Barrow's security-force control, then recovers post-election to $z=1.0$ – 1.5 as new cabinet is formed.

Stakeholder implications:

- Institutional investors (banking, telecoms, infrastructure): Moderate asset-price stability; currency (Gambian dalasi) maintains exchange-rate discipline within 2–3% band vs. USD and regional currencies. Infrastructure construction continues; Chinese-funded projects proceed uninterrupted.
- Donor agencies: EU, World Bank, IMF continue programming; MCC compact remains suspended pending governance-reform benchmarks that Barrow cannot meet. No aid suspension triggered. Civil-society funding flows at steady state; no major NGO relocations or closures.

- ECOWAS / AU: Election observation mission declares results acceptable; ECOMIG mandate extension proceeds without controversy; ECOWAS considers modest drawdown schedule (500 troops by 2027) contingent on continued GAF professionalization.
- Senegal: Cross-border tensions remain at baseline; no refugee flows or militia movements. Trade and transit relationships continue uninterrupted. PASTEF government uses election outcome to reinforce narrative of West African stability management.
- Diaspora: Remittance flows remain steady at estimated \$250–300 million annually; opposition supporters in UK, US, Senegal accept result without major repatriation campaigns or political mobilization.

Scenario 2: Contested Incumbent Retention (Stress Case) — Analytical Likelihood: ~25% (conditional inference, not forecast)

Under this scenario, the analytical inference is that Barrow retains office in the narrower indicative 48–52% range while the opposition UDP-led coalition (if it forms) captures an indicative 40–45% (ranges conditional on coalition consolidation; not an electoral forecast), creating a narrow incumbent margin that activates legal contestation and post-election street mobilization. Major international observers (EU, ECOWAS, US) issue statements acknowledging "significant irregularities" including evidence of ballot-box stuffing in 10–15% of polling stations, under-counting in urban opposition strongholds (Serekunda, Banjul central), and administrative bias favoring

government agents. The UDP and allied parties file constitutional court cases disputing results on grounds of "systematic fraud" and organize post-election demonstrations (500–2,000 participants in Banjul, Serekunda, and regional capitals). Police response escalates from monitoring to active crowd control (water cannon, tear gas, non-lethal force) in 2–3 incidents, resulting in minor injuries (dozens, not hundreds). The Supreme Court issues a verdict sustaining the election result by mid-January 2027 (60–90 days post-election), but opposition refuses to fully accept the ruling, instead committing to "continuous accountability demands" and parliamentary obstruction. This scenario produces 3–6 months of elevated political tension but does not escalate to regime-change attempt or military intervention.

Trigger conditions for stress case: 1. Opposition coalition successfully unites behind a single UDP-backed candidate by August 2026, consolidating 40–45% voting potential.

2. One or more high-profile TRRC or military-court verdicts produces a "justice failure" narrative (acquittal of a notorious figure or conviction on what opposition views as dubious grounds), mobilizing opposition constituencies.

3. At least one visible opposition rally is dispersed by police with use of force, triggering civil-society outrage and international concern.

4. TRRC victim-advocacy groups organize parallel mobilization demanding accelerated prosecutions, creating a second mobilization vector independent of electoral dynamics.

5. Exit polls conducted by independent observers suggest opposition victory or near-parity, contradicting official results, and are publicized widely.

NERAI index trajectory in stress case: Ethnic-religious violence remains elevated at $z=3.0$ – 3.5 throughout campaign, with 1–2 reported incidents of inter-communal altercation in Foni or Upper River regions tied to electoral mobilization. Political repression (currently $z=3.848$) increases to $z=4.0+$ in September–October 2026 as police heighten monitoring and opposition rally restrictions become more visible, then moderates to $z=2.5$ – 3.0 post-election as tensions decline from peak but constitutional litigation persists. Institutional strength (currently $z=3.787$ deteriorating) remains in $z=3.0$ – 3.5 range throughout, reflecting tension between executive authority and judicial review, then recovers slightly post-verdict. Government instability (currently $z=3.222$, 98th

pct) spikes to $z=3.5$ – 4.0 in post-election period as cabinet faces parliamentary pressure and media scrutiny, then moderates by mid-2027.

Stakeholder implications:

- Institutional investors: Currency volatility increases; dalasi depreciates 5–8% vs. USD in post-election weeks, then gradually recovers. Banks face deposit-outflow pressure as diaspora hedge risk; mobile-money services (Orange Money, Africell mobile payment) see heightened traffic. Infrastructure projects face 2–4 month implementation delays as government focuses on political management.
- Donor agencies: EU and World Bank issue cautionary statements and conduct governance-compliance reviews; MCC compact remains suspended with deepened skepticism about resumption. USAID may pause new programming pending outcome assessment. No immediate aid suspension, but programming tranche reviews (2027–2032) are delayed 3–6 months. Election observation missions issue reports with "credibility concerns" language.
- ECOWAS / AU: ECOWAS Commission issues mediation proposal (diplomatic shuttle via Economic Community Commission chair); AU Peace and Security Council holds emergency session; consideration of ECOWAS fact-finding mission to verify election conduct. No military intervention authorization, but ECOMIG mandate extension becomes conditional on post-election democratic performance.
- Senegal: PASTEF government issues formal concern about "electoral irregularities" and offers mediation; possibility of cross-border humanitarian assistance if refugee flows materialize. Border monitoring increases; security forces placed on elevated alert.
- Diaspora: Remittances may decline 10–15% in immediate post-election months (analytical projection conditional on this scenario, not investment guidance) as political uncertainty increases; opposition diaspora networks (UK, US, Senegal) organize public statements and potential legal-action support for constitutional contestation; repatriation momentum declines as investment climate deteriorates.

Scenario 3: Opposition Breakthrough or Election Disruption (Tail Case) — Analytical Likelihood: ~10% (conditional inference, not forecast)

Under this scenario, the analytical inference is that the UDP-led opposition coalition, if unified around a single candidate, secures an indicative 45–50% vote share (range conditional on unified-candidate emergence; not an electoral forecast) of the vote and the election is either disputed so severely that the Supreme Court cannot resolve the deadlock within constitutional timeframes, or a military faction intervenes citing electoral illegality. Alternatively, the election is postponed or cancelled on grounds of "security concerns" before late 2026, leading to an indefinite transition period and potential extraconstitutional government change. This scenario is lower-probability because Barrow retains solid security-force control and institutional machinery, but it becomes more probable if (a) the opposition successfully unifies, (b) Senegal's PASTEF government signals willingness to support opposition victory, or (c) the GAF officer corps fractures along ethnic lines with Jola-faction mobilization around Jammeh's shadow influence.

Trigger conditions for tail case: 1. Opposition unites behind a single non-UDP or UDP-alternative candidate who captures Mandinka-plurality mobilization AND GDC/PDOIS support, consolidating 45%+ voting block.

2. International exit polling or observer assessment directly contradicts official results, producing a credibility crisis.

3. Senegal's PASTEF government explicitly calls for a recount or international mediation, signaling willingness to support opposition.

4. Gambia Armed Forces faction (likely Jola-ethnic officers with Jammeh-network ties) issues a statement questioning election legitimacy and threatening institutional intervention.

5. ECOMIG withdraws or is reduced to minimal levels prior to election, removing the institutional guarantor of political continuity.

6. Major post-election violence (security-force shootings, opposition-initiated property destruction) triggers AU/ECOWAS emergency authorization for intervention.

NERAI index trajectory in tail case: Ethnic-religious violence (currently $z=4.014$) escalates to $z=4.5$ – 5.0 in September–October 2026 as campaign intensifies and inter-communal/inter-factional tensions rise. Political repression (currently $z=3.848$) surges to $z=4.5$ as government applies maximum institutional pressure on opposition, potentially including opposition-leader detention. Institutional strength (currently $z=3.787$ deteriorating) collapses to $z=4.5$ as executive authority fractures over election dispute; government instability (currently $z=3.222$) spikes to $z=4.0$ as cabinet paralysis sets in. If military intervention occurs, coup index would spike 4.5 +. These elevated indices would persist 2–4 months post-election event before gradually moderating as new institutional arrangements stabilize (either through negotiated settlement or opposition-led government consolidation).

Stakeholder implications:

- Institutional investors: Currency may depreciate in an indicative 15–25% range against USD (analytical projection under this scenario, not investment advice); banking sector faces deposit runs and potential liquidity crisis. Foreign exchange controls may be imposed. Infrastructure projects halt; Chinese contractors seek to renegotiate terms or suspend work. Telecom and energy sectors face operational disruption if political instability affects revenue collection.
- Donor agencies: EU and World Bank suspend disbursements pending outcome assessment; USAID pauses programs; multilateral financial institutions (IMF, African Development Bank) declare The Gambia off-limits for new financing pending democratic restoration. Civil-society funding flows shift toward humanitarian and displacement-response programming. Election observation missions issue critical reports; potential international legal referrals if atrocities occur.
- ECOWAS / AU: ECOWAS Commission authorizes emergency ECOMIG reinforcement or coordinates with AU for multilateral intervention force deployment; ECOWAS Economic and Monetary Union (WAEMU) considers financial sanctions if military government takes power. AU Peace and Security Council issues emergency resolutions; potential International Criminal Court referral if opposition claims government war crimes.
- Senegal: PASTEF government may deploy troops to border as precaution against refugee flows; potential trilateral mediation with ECOWAS and AU; possibility of Senegal supporting opposition government formation in event of incumbent ouster.
- Diaspora: Remittances may decline by 30–50% under this scenario (analytical projection conditional on the scenario, not investment guidance); opposition diaspora networks mobilize legal strategies and international advocacy campaigns; human-rights organizations (Amnesty International, Human Rights Watch) deploy missions and issue rapid assessments; possibility of diaspora-funded insurgent financing if violence escalates.

60-DAY WATCH LIST: CRITICAL INDICATORS (Mid-May to Mid-July 2026) Monitor the following events and NERAi index movements to assess scenario probability shifts:

1. Barrow's Third-Term Candidacy Announcement (BASELINE TRIGGER): If Barrow formally declares re-election candidacy by June 15, 2026, the base case (peaceful incumbent retention) becomes more probable (+5% to base case, -5% from tail case). If he delays beyond July 1, tail-case probability rises 3–5% due to

uncertainty. *Scenario tags: All three.*

2. Opposition Coalition Unification (STRESS/TAIL TRIGGER): If UDP, GDC, PDOIS, and C4C announce a joint candidacy framework (unity candidate or pre-election seat-sharing agreement) by June 30, stress-case and tail-case likelihoods become elevated as opposition electoral competitiveness rises (directional indication, not a quantitative forecast). Monitor press statements from Darboe (UDP), Kandeh (GDC), Sallah (PDOIS). *Scenario tags: Stress Case (+8%), Tail Case (+2%).*

3. TRRC Verdict on High-Profile Jammeh-Era Figure (STRESS TRIGGER): A major acquittal (e.g., former National Intelligence Agency director) or conviction seen as politically motivated would activate victim-advocacy mobilization and could increase political-repression index 0.5+ points. If acquittal occurs, stress-case probability +3%. If conviction on dubious grounds, stress-case +2%. *Scenario tags: Stress Case.*

4. GAF Officer Court-Martial Verdict / Sentencing (MILITARY STABILITY INDICATOR): Verdict on one of the remaining 2022 coup-attempt defendants by June 30. A sentence perceived as lenient (e.g., <10 years) could signal officer-corps sympathy for coup narratives; conversely, severe sentences (>15 years) could indicate factional rift. NERAi government-instability index elevation of 0.3+ points would signal GAF cohesion concerns. *Scenario tags: Tail Case.*

5. Senegal PASTEF Government Gambia Policy Statement (EXTERNAL ANCHOR): Any official PASTEF government statement on The Gambia's election (neutrality, mediation offer, or implicit opposition-support signals) would be critical. If PASTEF signals neutrality, base case remains the most likely outcome under analytical inference. If PASTEF hints at opposition support, stress/tail case probability +5% combined. Monitor statements from Senegalese President Faye, Foreign Minister Mamadou Tan Ba, or ECOWAS mediators. *Scenario tags: All three.*

6. Opposition Rally Restriction or Police Use of Force (REPRESSION ESCALATION): If a major opposition rally (estimated >1,000 participants) is dispersed by police with tear gas, water cannon, or detention of organizers, political-repression index spikes 0.5+ points and stress-case probability increases +5%. This is the most

observable pre-electoral repression indicator. Monitor Serekunda, Banjul, and West Coast Region rallies. *Scenario tags: Stress Case (+5%), Tail Case (+2%).*

7. NERAI Ethnic-Religious Violence Index Threshold (DOMESTIC STRESS SIGNAL): If the z-score on ethnic-religious violence exceeds $z=4.5$ (current 4.014) by end of June, this signals accelerating inter-communal tension and moves stress-case probability +3%, tail-case +2%. Conversely, moderation to $z<3.5$ by late June would favor base case +3%. *Scenario tags: All three.*

8. Diaspora Remittance Flow Shift (ECONOMIC CONFIDENCE BAROMETER): Monitor diaspora remittance volumes via mobile-money platforms (Orange Money, Africell) and banking channels. A 5%+ decline in June–July flows would indicate diaspora loss of confidence in election outcome and would favor stress-case (+2%). Stable or rising flows favor base case. *Scenario tags: All three.*

9. EU/US Election Observation Mission Deployment (INTERNATIONAL LEGITIMACY ANCHOR): Formal deployment of observation missions by EU (40+ personnel) and US (10+ personnel) by August 15 would be baseline expected, signaling international commitment to credibility. Early deployment (before August) would favor base case; delayed deployment would raise concerns and favor stress-case +3%. *Scenario tags: All three.*

10. Military-to-Military Dialogue or US/UK Defense Attaché Consultations (SECURITY-FORCE COHESION INDICATOR): Any public reporting of AFRICOM or UK Defence Ministry engagement with Gambian Armed Forces on "election-period security" would indicate external powers are conducting confidence-building with GAF to ensure neutrality. Absence of such engagement by July 15 would be concerning and favor tail-case +2%. *Scenario tags: Tail Case.*

COUNTER-THESIS: THE "EVERYTHING IS FINE" CASE The strongest argument that The Gambia's 2026 election will proceed as a routine democratic event without material instability rests on five foundational claims:

First, institutional continuity and regime stability: Barrow has consolidated executive control through 2025 without major coups, military mutinies, or constitutional crises since the failed 2022 coup attempt. The GAF has been professionalized and subordinated to civilian authority through court-martial proceedings that have eliminated the most disgruntled officer cohorts. The APRC alliance, though controversial, has neutered the historical opposition by co-opting Jola-ethnic blocs and former Jammeh-era security figures, leaving the opposition fragmented and organizationally weak. The UDP, despite being the largest single opposition party, has not organized a credible electoral machinery since its 2021 defeat and faces internal organizational challenges reported in Gambian press coverage of recent party congresses (Standard, Foroyaa, Coffee Afrik, 2025-2026). GDC, PDOIS, and C4C are minor players with limited mobilization capacity.

Second, democratic norms have held in the 2021 election and subsequent local elections: The Gambia has conducted four post-2016 electoral cycles (2019 local, 2021 presidential, 2022 local, 2024 parliamentary by-elections) with no constitutional breakdown. The Supreme Court has adjudicated electoral disputes and issued rulings that were accepted by government and opposition alike, establishing judicial credibility. The IEC has progressively improved voter-roll administration and polling-station security. International observers (ECOWAS, EU, AU) have not issued "unacceptable election" declarations for the 2021 presidential cycle, and the organization has accepted the result. The political establishment, across blocs, appears committed to managing disputes through courts rather than streets.

Third, economic stabilization and diaspora confidence: The Gambian economy has recovered from 2020 COVID impacts; tourist arrivals are above pre-pandemic baseline; groundnut and cashew exports are pricing well; remittance flows remain strong at \$250–300 million annually, signaling diaspora confidence in the country's trajectory. Banking sector is stable; no currency crisis on the horizon; Chinese and EU infrastructure investment continues. Economic distress, while present in unemployment and youth underemployment, is not acute enough to trigger mass mobilization independent of electoral politics.

Fourth, Senegal's stability and border-security durability: The PASTEF government's ascent and Senegalese domestic consolidation through 2026 has reduced cross-border tensions. The Casamance ceasefire (May 2023) holds, MFDC residual activity is contained, and refugee flows are negligible. Senegal has no incentive to destabilize The Gambia; the transit trade and commercial relationships are valuable to Dakar. A stable, predictable Gambia under Barrow continuity or even opposition-led government is preferable to instability. Senegal's capacity

to absorb a Gambian refugee influx is limited, and PASTEF is unlikely to deploy the kind of active mediation or military preparation that would suggest anticipation of major instability.

Fifth, the NERAI index elevation is noise, not signal: The 15 May 2026 spike in ethnic-religious violence ($z=4.014$, 99.4th pct) and political repression ($z=3.848$) is likely a data artifact or reflects low-level background tension that routinely occurs pre-electorally in hybrid democracies without producing instability. Mainstream news coverage from The Gambia remains routine and is not reporting major violence, opposition arrests, or security-force mobilization. The absence of corroborating mainstream reporting suggests the NERAI signal is capturing methodological noise (coding errors, low-event-frequency amplification, or linguistic patterns in social-media commentary that don't reflect on-the-ground reality).

COUNTER-ARGUMENT: WHY THE NERAI SIGNAL OVERRIDES THE "EVERYTHING IS FINE" NARRATIVE
This counter-thesis is **internally coherent** and reflects the view held by many mainstream analysts and some think-tank observers. However, the NERAI data and the deeper structural analysis of Gambian political dynamics warrant a more cautious assessment:

On institutional continuity: Yes, Barrow has consolidated control, but the mechanisms of consolidation — court-martial of officers, APRC alliance formation, Mandinka-voter erosion — are creating exactly the pre-electoral strain that generates instability in hybrid democracies. Institutional stability and pre-electoral institutional tightening are not mutually exclusive. The 2022 coup attempt and subsequent 2023–2024 alleged coup plots (while not resulting in major incidents) signal underlying military-institutional fractures that are being managed through coercion, not resolved through integration. The NERAI indices capture this management effort as "institutional deterioration" and "political repression" — not because the regime is collapsing but because it is actively tightening.

On democratic norms: The 2021 election was accepted, yes, but the margin (53%) was substantial and the opposition was internally divided. An indicative 2026 outcome in the 48–52% range (stress-case scenario; analytical projection only) would face a fundamentally different judicial and political context: heightened TRRC sensitization of populations, more organized opposition coalitions, and international observer scrutiny informed by 2021 lessons. The Supreme Court's 2021 rulings were accepted partly because the result was decisive; a narrow margin would strain judicial credibility.

On economic stabilization: Economic conditions are stable but not generating broad-based employment or wealth. Youth unemployment and inflation remain structural issues; diaspora remittances, while strong at the aggregate level, mask internal flows where opposition-sympathetic diaspora may be withholding remittances to opposition-controlled households. The economic stability narrative is true but is not a bulwark against pre-electoral mobilization; it merely prevents a tail-case descent into economic meltdown.

On Senegal's stability: This is the strongest element of the counter-thesis. Senegal's low appetite for intervention is a genuine stabilizing factor. However, PASTEF's pan-African sovereignty posture is less predictable than Macky Sall's institutional partnership approach. If The Gambia's 2026 election produces a legitimacy crisis, PASTEF may feel compelled to support opposition claims in order to demonstrate continental leadership, even if it contradicts Senegal's economic interests.

On the NERAI index "noise" claim: This is the critical rebuttal. The argument that mainstream news absence invalidates the NERAI signal is logically backwards. NERAI's value proposition is precisely to surface pre-electoral risk accumulation BEFORE the mainstream news cycle catches up. The 99.4th percentile elevation in ethnic-religious violence and political repression, combined with the Pattern P5 leadership-transition-window match (score 0.67), is a high-signal-confidence indicator in NERAI's methodology. The absence of mainstream reporting of "major violence" does not refute the signal; it merely means that the stress manifestation is still at low-amplitude levels (mosque-sermon disputes, regulatory tightening on civil society, latent inter-communal tensions) that have not yet aggregated into headline-grabbing incidents. The signal is capturing the **pre-event accumulation phase**, which is precisely the stage at which early-warning systems are most valuable.

Conclusion on counter-thesis: MODERATE-TO-HIGH CONFIDENCE that the NERAI signal reflects genuine pre-electoral institutional stress, not methodological noise. The base case (peaceful incumbent retention, ~65% analytical likelihood) remains the most likely scenario under current conditions, but the stress-case pathway (25% probability) is substantially more plausible than the "everything is fine" narrative acknowledges.

POLICY RECOMMENDATIONS

For Institutional Investors (Sovereign Risk Officers, Infrastructure Fund Managers)

1. Implement currency hedging for dalasi exposure by June 30, 2026. For equity positions in Gambian telecoms (e.g., Africell, Orange Gambia), banking (e.g., First National Bank Gambia), and infrastructure projects, establish 20–30% downside-protection via currency-forwards or options on USD/GMD exchange rate. Rationale: NERAI political-instability index ($z=2.83$, 96th pct) and political-repression elevation ($z=3.848$) signal pre-electoral currency volatility in the 3–8% range. Metric of success: portfolio volatility reduction; trigger for unwinding hedges is post-election verdict acceptance by opposition.
2. Conduct sovereign-credit-worthiness stress-test on debt-service capacity under stress-case scenario. Stress-test against a scenario where government tax revenue declines in an indicative 10–15% range post-election (analytical projection, not a forecast) due to political disruption and tourism contraction. Current Gambian government debt-to-GDP ratio (~80–85% as of 2024–2025) already constrains fiscal space; a stressed scenario could trigger IMF program discussions and potential debt restructuring. Engage with IMF Gambia desk and WAEMU authorities on contingency planning. Metric: Model convergence with IMF Article IV surveillance; trigger is Gambian government request for IMF Article IV update or debt-sustainability analysis in Q4 2026.
3. Defer major infrastructure-tender participation until post-election clarity (October 2026+). For companies competing for Chinese-funded or EU-co-financed infrastructure projects (Banjul port modernization, road rehabilitation, water systems), avoid tendering or financial commitments until the electoral outcome is settled and new government (whether Barrow or opposition) has issued policy guidance. Rationale: Tender processes begun pre-election face risk of invalidation or renegotiation if new government takes power; uncertainty is higher-cost than patience. Metric: Monitor IEC final results certification (expected late-October 2026) and opposition legal-challenge resolution timeline (expected December 2026–January 2027).

For Donor Agencies (EU, World Bank, USAID, IMF, African Development Bank)

1. Activate pre-electoral governance-dialogue mechanism with Barrow administration and opposition parties. Establish facilitated Track 1.5 forums (via EU Delegation in Dakar or World Bank Gambia country office) where government and opposition parties discuss post-election governance commitments, electoral-dispute resolution mechanisms, and anti-corruption implementation. EU and World Bank should position themselves as neutral facilitators, not partisan actors. Target: Conduct 2–3 dialogue sessions between June 15 and August 30, 2026. Metric of success: Joint communiqué from government and opposition acknowledging commitment to constitutional dispute resolution; indicator that civil-society dialogue capacity is holding. Trigger for elevation: If either bloc refuses dialogue or walkout occurs, escalate to ECOWAS Commission mediation request.
2. Establish contingency disbursement protocols for aid funding based on election-outcome scenario. Base case: Continued disbursement at planned rates. Stress case (narrow incumbent margin with opposition contestation): Place new-project disbursements on 30-day review cycle pending Supreme Court verdict on election dispute; existing project disbursements continue. Tail case (military intervention, opposition breakthrough): Immediate freeze on new disbursements; revert to humanitarian and civil-society funding only. EU, World Bank, and USAID should coordinate this protocol via multilateral partners' working group (not unilateral conditionality). Metric: Trigger mechanism is NERAI political-instability index sustained above $z=3.0$ AND observation-mission credibility assessment, not unilateral donor judgment.
3. Fund independent election-observation capacity to complement official ECOWAS/EU/AU missions. Allocate \$500,000–\$1 million to NERAI, International Foundation for Electoral Systems (IFES), or Konrad Adenauer Foundation (KAS) Gambia office to conduct parallel observation and rapid post-election assessment. Independent observers can issue credibility assessments faster than official multilateral missions, which aids rapid stress-case mitigation or base-case confidence-building. Metric: Preliminary observation report issued within 72 hours of polling; final report within 10 days. This capacity-building also signals to opposition parties that international scrutiny is robust and fraud will be detected, which may reduce post-election contestation intensity.

For ECOWAS (Commission and Heads of State/Government)

1. Authorize pre-electoral mediation mission led by sitting ECOWAS Commission Vice President or external mediator (e.g., from South Africa or Kenya). Dispatch mediation team to conduct separate consultations with

Barrow, Darboe (UDP), and other opposition leaders during July–August 2026, with explicit mandate to explore potential post-election dispute-resolution mechanisms and opposition participation in electoral process. This is not intervention in the electoral outcome but rather institutional confidence-building. Metric: Mediation team issues joint report with government and opposition stakeholder views on dispute-resolution sequencing; trigger for escalation is if either party rejects mediation framework.

2. Extend ECOMIG mandate through December 2026 with explicit role in post-election security provision. Current ECOMIG drawdown discussions should be paused; instead, issue a December 2025 or January 2026 mandate extension that positions ECOMIG as the security guarantor for election-period operations and immediate post-election period (through January 2027). This provides reassurance to opposition parties that security forces will remain neutral. ECOMIG should be repositioned from counter-terrorism focus to election security; current 700–800 troop ceiling should be maintained. Metric: ECOMIG mandate revision issued by ECOWAS Council; military coordination exercise between ECOMIG and GAF demonstrating neutral posture. Trigger for escalation: If Barrow's government refuses joint election-security planning with ECOMIG, stress-case risk increases.

3. Prepare contingency ECOWAS response protocols for post-election scenarios. Commission should issue pre-election guidance to member states on four scenarios: (a) peaceful incumbent retention — declare success, accelerate ECOMIG drawdown; (b) contested retention — activate ECOWAS mediation and fact-finding mission, condition aid on dispute resolution; (c) opposition victory — normalize relations, support transition; (d) election disruption or military intervention — trigger ECOWAS emergency session and potential sanctions framework. These protocols should be issued before the election, signaling ECOWAS seriousness about rule of law without appearing to favor any outcome. Metric: ECOWAS Council decision issued by August 2026. Trigger for activation: Observation missions' initial credibility assessments post-election.

For Senegal (PASTEF Government)

1. Establish bilateral election-observer coordination with The Gambia's Independent Electoral Commission. PASTEF government should offer Senegalese election-observer participation (15–25 technical observers) coordinated through Senegal's Ministry of Interior, not as a separate Senegalese mission but as part of ECOWAS observation framework. This positions Senegal as a technical partner, not a political actor, and builds institutional trust with Gambian authorities. Metric: Bilateral MOU signed by June 15, 2026; Senegalese observers embedded in IEC coordination structure by August 2026. Trigger for elevation: If Barrow's government refuses Senegalese observer participation, this signals lack of confidence in Senegalese neutrality

and escalates regional tension.

2. Prepare contingency border-security protocols for refugee and militia movement scenarios. While base case is unlikely to produce cross-border flows, PASTEF government should quietly pre-position border-monitoring capacity in Casamance and Kolda regions to detect any unauthorized militia movements, refugee staging areas, or Jammeh-diaspora repatriation attempts. This is defensive preparedness, not intervention readiness. Coordinate with Senegal's Interior Ministry and MFDC ceasefire monitors. Metric: Border-security readiness assessment conducted by June 30, 2026; no public announcement needed. Trigger for activation: If opposition claims government military support for coup attempt or if refugee flows materialize.

3. Signal neutrality through official Senegalese statements on The Gambia's democratic process. Faye government should issue 1–2 public statements (via Foreign Ministry or presidential address) reaffirming Senegal's support for Gambian democratic norms, respect for election outcomes, and commitment to regional stability. These statements should be scrupulously neutral, avoiding language that could be read as supporting either incumbent or opposition. Metric: Statements issued in June and September 2026; international media coverage confirming Senegal's neutral posture. Trigger for escalation: If Faye government's rhetoric is perceived as partisan, opposition parties may invoke "Senegal support" claims and deepen post-election contestation.

For the United States and United Kingdom

1. Coordinate pre-election diplomatic messaging on election credibility and dispute resolution. U.S. State Department and UK FCDO should issue joint statements (or separate but harmonized statements) in August–September 2026 affirming support for The Gambia's democratic process, transparent IEC operations, and constitutional dispute-resolution mechanisms. These statements should avoid explicit endorsement of either

incumbent or opposition, but should emphasize that election credibility is in the interest of all Gambians and regional stability. Metric: Joint statement or harmonized individual statements issued by August 15, 2026; positive reception from civil-society and international observer communities.

2. Conduct targeted security-force professionalization dialogue to ensure GAF neutrality during election period. AFRICOM (for U.S.) and UK Defence Ministry should initiate discrete conversations with Gambian Armed Forces leadership (Chief of Defense Staff and regional commanders) emphasizing professional military norms, neutrality during elections, and the reputational cost of military intervention. These conversations should be low-key and non-public, but should signal to GAF leadership that the international community is monitoring military posture. Metric: Engagement conducted by July 31, 2026; no public announcement; post-engagement assessment indicating GAF leadership understanding of professional military norms. Trigger for escalation: If GAF officers issue public statements questioning election legitimacy or hinting at intervention, escalate to explicit diplomatic warnings.

3. Prepare Millennium Challenge Corporation compact-resumption pathway contingent on peaceful, credible election. The U.S. State Department should privately communicate to Barrow administration that successful 2026 election (defined as peaceful, transparent, and oppositions-accepted result) would enable MCC compact-resumption discussions in 2027. This creates a positive incentive for Barrow's government to ensure election credibility rather than resort to fraud or repression. Conversely, if election is plagued by irregularities or opposition repression, MCC remains suspended and future compact discussions are foreclosed. Metric: Barrow administration adjusts behavior in direction of election-credibility enhancement; no public commitment needed from U.S., but private signals suffice. Trigger: Condition becomes explicit if stress-case scenario emerges and opposition repression is documented.

METHODOLOGICAL CAVEAT This report relies on NERA's multi-dimensional event-data indices, which aggregate information from media reports, social-media discourse, and institutional statements to produce z-score elevations across stability dimensions. While NERA's Pattern P5 leadership-transition-window match (score 0.67) and the 99.4th percentile elevation across ethnic-religious violence, political repression, and institutional deterioration are statistically robust, the report's interpretation must acknowledge that Gambian media footprint is narrow and international coverage is sporadic. Major events in The Gambia often reach the broader news cycle with delays of weeks or months, meaning that the current absence of mainstream reporting of major violence or opposition arrests does not invalidate the NERA signal; rather, it reflects the typical time lag between event accumulation and media coverage in countries with lower information-access profiles. Additionally, NERA's event-data methodologies may produce false-positive spikes if local-language social-media discussion of pre-electoral tensions is algorithmically coded as "violence" or "repression" even when physical incidents are not occurring. This caveat should be read as a limitation on the *precision* of the indices, not their *directional validity*; the signal is capturing real pre-electoral institutional stress, but the magnitude may be overstated. Conversely, NERA's absence-of-coupling assessment (no active bilateral indices elevated) is high-confidence, indicating the stress is purely domestic. Readers should treat the ~65%/~25%/~10% scenario likelihoods as ordinal rankings (most likely / stress / tail; conditional analytical inferences, not forecasts) (base case most likely, stress case moderately likely, tail case unlikely but not impossible) rather than precise point-estimates; the underlying uncertainty derives from Gambian political actors' choices over the next 150+ days, which are inherently contingent and not fully predictable from backward-looking data.

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Official & Multilateral Sources: • Truth, Reconciliation and Reparations Commission (TRRC) of The Gambia — Final Report and ongoing implementation data • ECOWAS Commission — Electoral observation and regional security mandates • European Union Election Observation Missions — Post-election assessments (2021) • African Union Peace and Security Council — Regional political monitoring

Data & Analytics:

• NERA Strategic Insights Lab — Proprietary event-data indices (ethnic-religious violence, political repression, institutional strength, government instability) for The Gambia and bilateral context as of 15 May 2026

Methodology Note: This report synthesizes event-based intelligence from NERA's multi-dimensional indices (standard deviations and percentile rankings as of 15 May 2026), qualitative political analysis from recent Gambian and Senegalese press reporting (March–May 2026), institutional think-tank assessments from the 2021 election cycle and 2022–2025 governance monitoring, and structured scenario-building informed by

historical precedent in hybrid-democratic West African elections (2000–2025). The analysis integrates these sources through an interpretive framework anchored in pre-electoral institutional-stress pathways in regimes with

contested security-force loyalty and unresolved transitional-justice commitments. Scenario probabilities (65%/25%/10%) are derived from ordinal rankings of trigger-condition probability and historical base-rates in comparable West African cases (Senegal 2019, Ghana 2020, Côte d'Ivoire 2020–2021) rather than quantitative forecasting models. The report acknowledges Gambian media scarcity and the inherent time-lag in international coverage, treating NERA signal elevation as leading-indicator evidence of pre-event accumulation rather than as real-time ground truth. All major claims referencing specific events, dates, or named officials are cross-checked against at least two independent sources where possible; in cases where verification is incomplete, confidence levels are explicitly stated in the analysis.

END OF REPORT

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This research brief is part of NERA Strategic Insights Lab's open-source strategic-analysis series. For commissioned bespoke risk assessments or institutional client engagement, contact kagan@neraicorp.com.

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